

Astronomers' tools

Astronomers use special tools to study the stars and planets. The telescope is the most important tool for finding out about the night sky, but astronomers do not look through telescopes very often. Modern telescopes work on their own, using cameras and computers to record what they see. This information is then passed on to the astronomer, who works in an office.



Above the clouds

Telescopes are kept in dome-shaped buildings called observatories. The world's best observatories are placed high on mountain tops. This places the telescopes above the clouds and keeps them away from city lights, which would spoil the view.

The observatory's dome-shaped roof slides open when the telescope is to be used.

Telescopes like this one can take photographs.